

From business to birds

Although Ali initially dropped out of college to manage his family's business interests in Burma, he later completed a degree in zoology. He was keen to make the study of birds in their environment his primary occupation and so sought training in Germany, under the well-respected ornithologist Erwin Stresemann. During his time here, he learned many new practices, such as bird ringing, which he would subsequently employ back in India. Ringing involves attaching a numbered ring to a bird's leg, which then allows the bird to be tracked and studied over its lifetime.



Between 1927 and 1929, Ali worked as a 'Guide Lecturer' in the Natural History section of the Prince of Wales Museum, Bombay,